

Readings

Isaiah 7:14

Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign: The virgin will be with child and will give birth to a son, and will call him Immanuel.

Luke 2:8-20

In that region there were shepherds living in the fields, keeping watch over their flock by night. Then an angel of the Lord stood before them, and the glory of the Lord shone around them, and they were terrified. But the angels said to them, "Do not be afraid; for see - I am bringing you good news of great joy for all the people: to you is born this day in the city of David, a Savior, who is the Messiah, the Lord. This will be a sign for you: you will find a child wrapped in swaddling clothes and lying in a manger." And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host, praising God and saying "Glory to God in the highest heaven and peace on earth among those whom God favors!" When the angels had left them and gone into heaven, the shepherds said to one another, "Let us go now to Bethlehem and see this thing that had taken place, which the Lord has made known to us." So they went with haste and found Mary and Joseph and the child lying in the manger. When they saw this,, they made known what had been told them about this child; and all who heard it were amazed at what the shepherds told them. But Mary treasured all these words and pondered them in her heart. The shepherds returned, glorifying and praising God for all they had heard and seen, as it had been told them.

God In The Feed Trough

Today I'd like to tell you a story. Our story begins with miracles, and signs, and excitement, and angels. This story has drama and plot twists, suspense and surprises. It is indeed a fascinating account. It begins in a time long ago and in a place far away. Settle back and listen.

In the days of King Herod of Judea, there was a priest named Zechariah and his wife was named Elizabeth. Both of them were righteous before God, living blamelessly according to all the commandments and regulation of the Lord. But they had no children, because Elizabeth was barren, and both were getting on in years.

One day, a very special day, Zechariah was serving God in the sanctuary of the temple, offering incense. There appeared to him an angel, standing on the right side of the altar. And when Zechariah saw him, he was terrified. But the angel said to him, "Do not be afraid, Zechariah, for your prayer has been heard. Your wife Elizabeth will bear you a son, and you will name him John. You will have joy and gladness, and many will rejoice at his birth, for he will be great in the sight of the Lord."

Zechariah was stunned. This was a great surprise. And he wasn't sure such a thing could really happen, at this stage in his life. So he said to the angel, How will I know this is so? For I am an old man, and my wife is getting on in years."

The angel replied, "I am Gabriel. I stand in the presence of God, and I have been sent to speak to you and to bring you this good news. But now, because you did not believe my words, which will be fulfilled in their time, you will become mute, unable to speak, until the day these things occur."

Still in shock, Zechariah stumbled through his work inside the temple and then went outside. And lo and behold, he could not talk! It was clear to the congregation that he had experienced something marvelous, a vision, yet he could not talk. Zechariah stayed on at the temple until his time of service was done, and then he returned home to his wife.

And after those days, his wife, Elizabeth, conceived, and for five months she remained in seclusion. She said "This is what the Lord has

done for me when he looked favorably on me and took away the disgrace I have endured among my people.

It was amazing. Zechariah and Elizabeth were going to have a baby! And no ordinary baby at that. This was going to be a wondrous child, dedicated from birth to the service of God. The baby would be a boy and should be named John.

Six months after this, God sent Gabriel down to the Galilean town of Nazareth to a young woman named Mary. Now Mary was engaged to Joseph and engagements back then were taken very seriously. The engagement period lasted about one year and to break this pledged match, one had to go through the process of divorce. Women were married very young back then. Mary was probably in her early teens.

And it is to this youthful woman that the mighty angel Gabriel appears. He greets her with the most fantastic greeting: "You who are highly favored! The Lord is with you!"

What an incredible thing to hear, from an angel no less. "You, who are highly favored! The Lord is with you!" It certainly took Mary off guard. She was much perplexed by his words and wondered what sort of greeting this might be.

Gabriel went on to tell Mary "Do not be afraid, Mary, for you have found favor with God. And now, you will conceive in your womb and bear a son, and you will name him Jesus. He will be great, and will be called the Son of the Most High, and the Lord God will give to him the throne of his ancestor David. He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of his kingdom there will be no end."

Now Mary, though young, was smarter than Zechariah. She didn't doubt the veracity of the angel's words. And though she may have thought it, she didn't ask, "Why me? How did I get to be so favored?" She just wanted to know how this was going to happen, since she was a virgin. And Gabriel said that the Holy Spirit would come upon her and overshadow her and she would be with child.

Mary said, "OK. So be it." Which is all one can really say when the chief angel tells you how it's going to be.

Our story progresses. Mary sets out with haste to a Judean town in the hill country to see her relative Elizabeth, Zechariah's wife. Mary

has heard from the angel that Elizabeth, who was barren, is now with child. Something miraculous is going on.

So Mary travels to see Elizabeth and true to the angel's words, she is indeed very pregnant. And when she sees Mary, Elizabeth breaks out into joyful prophecy, shouting "Blessed are you among women!" Even the baby within her womb leaps for joy!

Later, when Elizabeth's baby is born, he is named John, and another miracle happens. Zechariah gets his voice again. Things are going well and God is at work.

Now we come to our first real problem in our story. It concerns Mary and her pregnancy. In those days, for a woman to show up pregnant and unmarried was not just embarrassing or awkward. It was considered a crime. Any woman who was proven to be unchaste was seen as tainted goods. She was to be destroyed. She would be stoned and she would be killed. This is a truly suspenseful moment in our narrative.

But wait, in answer to this very real threat, God presents another miracle. When Mary's fiancé Joseph discovers this matter of her unwed pregnancy, he decides to divorce her quietly, rather than see her executed. But God sends Gabriel again, this time in a dream to Joseph. "Joseph, son of David, do not be afraid to take Mary as your wife, for the child conceived in her is from the Holy Spirit. She will bear a son, and you are to name him Jesus, for he will save his people from their sins."

God intervenes and Joseph has a change of heart. Rather than disowning Mary, even in a quiet divorce, he understands instead, that he needs to support and love her. Disaster has been averted. God has stepped in and provided a miracle.

"Blessed are you among women!...Highly favored of the Lord...Nothing is impossible with God!" How these words must have echoed in Mary's mind.

Mary's pregnancy progresses just fine. She gains weight. Her hormones and emotions go berserk. And she sends Joseph out at three in the morning for pickles and matzo balls.

And Mary must have allowed herself to dream. How wonderful it would be when this baby was born. He would be king. King of kings. And he would have a royal birth. After all, this child was conceived of

the Holy Spirit. This is God's own baby. She would have the finest midwife, no second rate ob-gyn nurse from the low cost clinic. And she would have someone to help after the delivery, as she lay resting in a clean, comfortable room surrounded by flowers and cute baby toys. Later, important dignitaries would come to offer congratulations. This is God's child.

Mary knows that she can count on these things. Over and over in our story, we have heard of God's intervention. Angels have appeared. Tidings of great joy have been proclaimed. Elizabeth was barren, and now she has a healthy, beautiful, baby boy. Joseph was distressed and Mary's life was at risk. And again an angel came. Now Joseph is supportive and attentive. Oh, to be carrying this child of God's. All will be well. God will take care of everything. It will be beautiful.

And then...then it all falls to pieces. Caesar Augustus calls for a census and each Jewish family must return to their tribal home. Joseph has to go back to Bethlehem because this is the city of his ancestor David. He has to take Mary with him so she can be counted as part of his family, for tax purposes.

Joseph is not a wealthy man. He has no vacation time due to him from the carpenter's shop where he works. Not only do Joseph and Mary lose the income he would have received while he was working. They also must spend money for the trip. They must use what little funds they had saved up.

Now, from Nazareth to Bethlehem is about 80 miles. The only way to travel back then was on foot, by cart, or on a donkey. There were no shock absorbers, padded seats, air conditioners, or even radio. And I can tell you. I love to ride horses. But even when I was in good riding shape, a long day on a horse just about did me in. It hurt to even try and walk. And I can only guess what it was like to travel those 80 miles and be very pregnant. You can almost imagine Mary saying to herself "When we get there, everything will be fine. God will take care of us. This is God's baby. God promised me. Blessed are you among women. Everything will be alright."

Well, Mary and Joseph finally make it to Bethlehem. And there is no room in the inn. Listen to that. There is no room at the inn. They are forced to stay in a stable. Now I personally love horses and cows

and sheep and chickens and such. But they stink. They are messy. And they are not house broken. And legend has it that the stable Mary and Joseph stayed in was a converted cave. And a cave, of course, has no ventilation system.

Mary has to be thinking to herself "Blessed are you among women! ... Highly favored of the Lord...Nothing is impossible with God!" But if nothing is impossible with God, is it really too much to ask for a room! And what about the clean sheets and help and care for the mother of God's baby? This is not going according to plan. This is not how Mary had pictured things would be!

"Highly favored of the Lord?" She wasn't even asking for a miracle, just a room, or a midwife, or at least a cleansing breeze in that cave! Now she begins to ask the question "Why me?"

And there, in this cave, converted into a stable, Mary has her baby. She is alone, except for her fiancé. She is not surrounded by loving friends. She does not have her mother proudly holding her hand. There are no cute osh b'gosh overalls from the baby shower. She will not get to rest quietly and be pampered afterward. She is alone, in a barn, having this baby. It does not feel like God is there. It does not seem that this impossible mess could be the delivery of the King of Kings into the world. Mary wonders if it can get much worse.

Where are the angels now? Remember all those angels visiting Zechariah, Joseph, and Mary? She could certainly use a little heavenly comfort. Just a song or two, a celestial chorus from above, reminding her that God had not forgotten her.

The angels do appear. But not to Mary. They show themselves to a collection of shepherds. And of course they come to visit Mary at the stable. Perhaps the only thing that could have added to the disappointment and frustration Mary must feel is if she had to play hostess to a bunch of unkempt shepherds who don't even know how to be dignified! No nobles arrive to pay tribute. No princes paying homage. No royalty at all. Just a company of shepherds. (The wise men we sing about at Christmas time do not actually come to visit the baby Jesus until he is about two years old.) At the time of his birth, in a stable in Bethlehem, away from her family and friends, Mary is visited only by those whose profession is to watch the sheep.

"Blessed are you among women!...Highly favored of the Lord...Nothing is impossible with God!"

And she took her first born, a son, and wrapped him in cloth and placed him in a manger. Let me tell you about a manger. It is a feed trough. It is where animals eat and slobber and get dirty. It is not the sugary image we get when we sing the song "Away in a manger, no crib for a bed, the little Lord Jesus lay down his sweet head." This is a feed trough. And this is where Mary lays her baby, Son of the Most High. Jesus. Son of God, in a feed trough.

I know what it is like when I am favored. I can describe for you how it is when God is with me. My relationships are loving and warm. My job is fulfilling, and I'm making enough money to make ends meet. My car works. It doesn't make funny sounds. My health is good, my weight is down, and life is really very fine. I know how it is when I am blessed.

And yet here, in the middle of a total fiasco, in the midst of tremendous disappointment and frustration, is God - in a feed trough. This is not the way I would have planned the birth of a king! This is all backward. And this is not how I understand God to be.

Let me tell you this about me. Maybe it even applies to you. While my mind may "know better," there is a part of me that thinks that if I am trying to live a good, spiritual, religious life, I should get a break. I mean, if I'm about the work of living out my beliefs as a religious person, it should be easier than if I was just going about life in a self-centered, materialist, careless way. Not that I'm expecting a life of no problems, but a bit of a break seems only fair. If I'm trying to be a good Christian, then it would seem reasonable that God would be on my side. At least a little bit.

"Blessed are you among women!...Highly favored of the Lord...Nothing is impossible with God!"

This story though, this story says it isn't so. While there were indeed miracles and angels, the very presence of God doesn't show up until it all goes down the tubes! God in a feed trough.

There, in the situations that seem like they can't get any worse, that's where God is. When it doesn't feel blessed. When it is smelly and dirty and all wrong. God...in the feed trough.

Think about your life. When things are not going well, when you can't believe your run of rotten luck. When you have lost your health, or the health of those you love is sorely compromised. When your family and relationships seem distant and stressed. When money is tight and there does not seem to be relief in sight. When your situation is far from ideal and you find yourself asking, "How did I end up like this?" When your life is anything other than what you had planned it to be. When you are alone and scared. Anytime when you feel anything but favored and blessed, remember Mary. There, in the middle of the mess, is God, in the feed trough.

Let me be clear here. I am not talking about being polyanna. I am not advocating the search for the silver lining in the cloud.... When life is as it is, and it is not at all what you'd planned, there, right there is God.

We recall the passage "Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and they shall name him Emmanuel". It is a beautiful name - Emmanuel. It means "God with us." Remember that. Remember this story. This is its message. God is with us. No matter how it may seem.

Blessed are you. Highly favored are you. Because nothing is impossible. Look into your personal feed troughs. There you will see God. Amenand Amen.